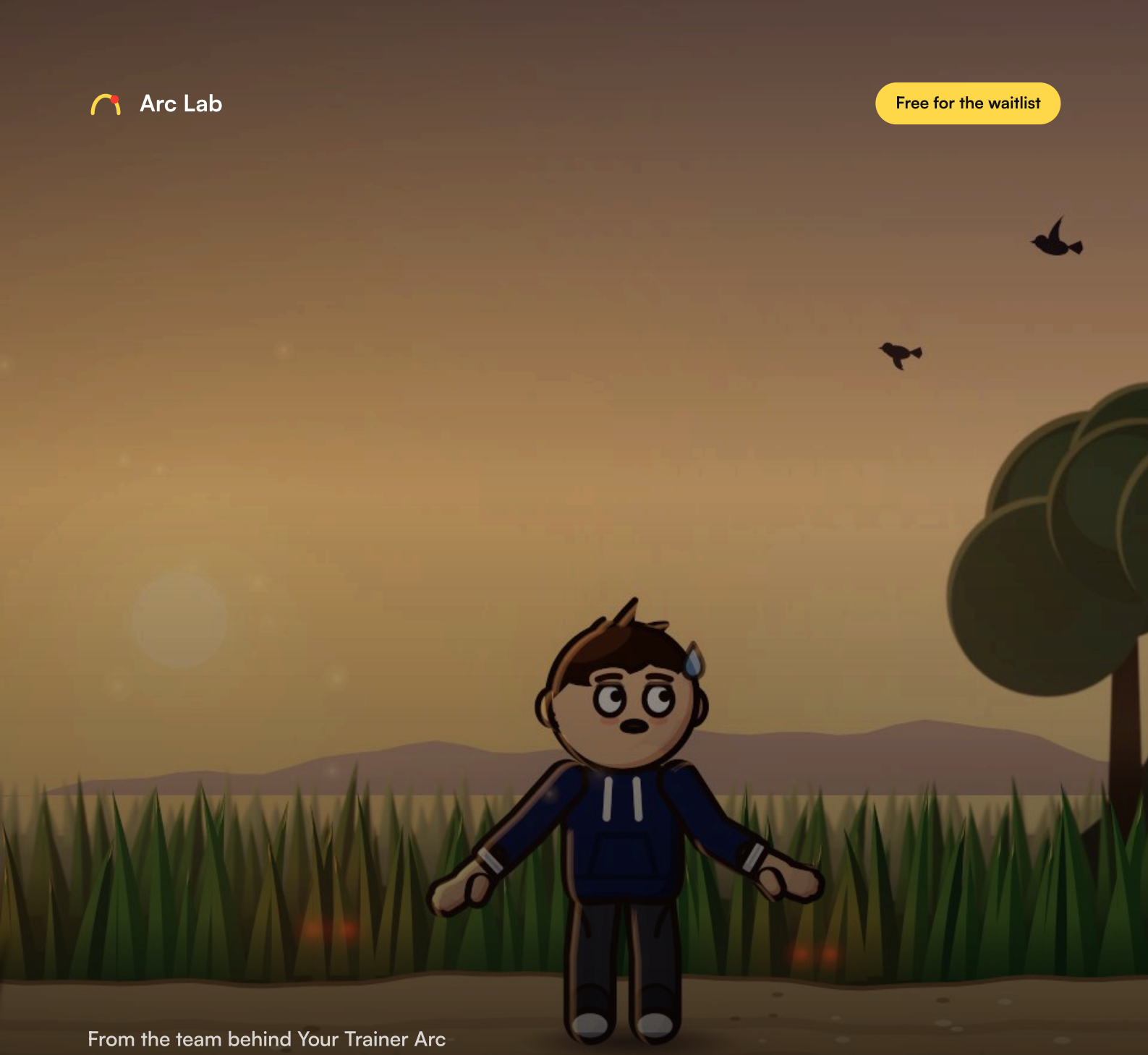
Arc Lab

Free for the waitlist



From the team behind Your Trainer Arc

The Vote Loop Playbook

How our series got 11,786 votes on one question in a day, and how to build the same loop into yours.

1.3M
Instagram views in its first week

11 chapters
with templates and checklists

October 2026

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What the loop did in one week

1.3M views in the first week	**422K** people reached	**94,000+** votes across the series
70–80% retention throughout every part	**94%** of views from people who didn't follow us yet	**10K** followers in 6 days

Views and reach are Instagram insights for @yourtrainerarc on 26 October 2026, seven parts in (YouTube not included). What worked for us is evidence, not a promise.

Chapter 1

The loop

Every part ends on a choice, and the next part opens on that choice. People come back because their answer is in the next video. That's the whole engine. The rest of this book is how to make each turn of it stronger.

1
Hook
Open inside the action, and credit last part's vote

2
Story
A chase, not a lecture

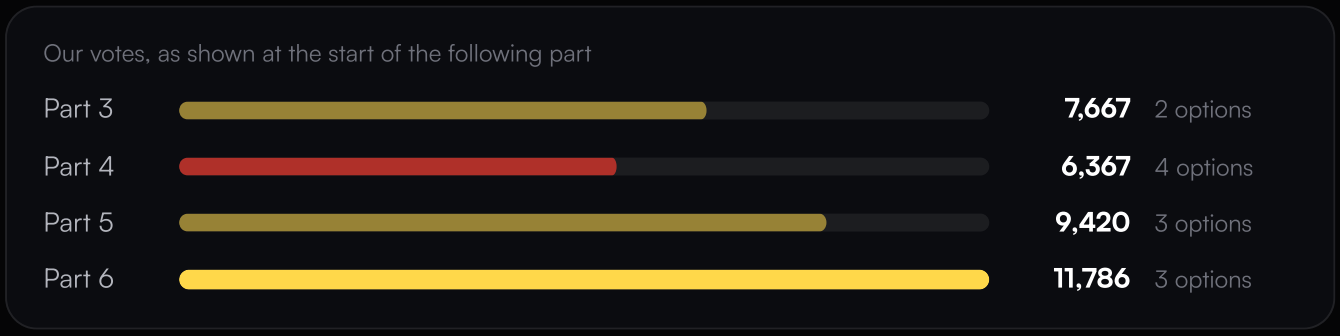
3
Cliffhanger
Stop exactly at the choice

4
Vote
Two or three physical options

5
Credit
"Most of you said..." opens the next part

Why it works

- **Votes make people comment.** In the story accounts we studied, reels without a vote got about 0.1 to 0.5 comments per 1,000 views. With a vote: 1 to 2.5. Comments tell the app people care.
- **Votes bring people back.** Our Part 2 kept 66% of Part 1's views (303K to 200K). The accounts we studied usually keep 30 to 50%.
- **Votes compound.** One story account kept 4 to 9 million views across six parts by opening each with "MOST OF YOU SAID...".



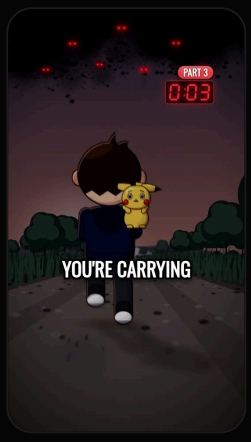
The one rule of the loop. A vote only works if it visibly changes the next part. If people vote and nothing changes, they stop voting.

Chapter 2

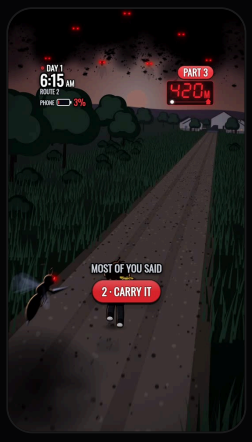
The hook

A new viewer decides in about a second. A returning viewer wants to know what happened to their vote. The first four seconds have to serve both.

- **Frame one is mid-action, with sound.** No title card, no "previously on", no slow push across scenery.
- **The first line is seven words or fewer.** Second person, present tense, one stake word coloured red.
- **Your star looks into the lens** in the first frame. A face beats a landscape.
- **Credit the vote by second four** with a stamp. Returning viewers see their choice before they can swipe.
- **One wide shot by second six** that shows the goal, the threat and the odds together.



0.3 s: already running



3.7 s: the vote, credited

Our Part 3, second by second

0.0 s	Running at night, a drill punching the dirt behind your heel, the creature staring into the lens.
0.0 s	"You're carrying a wild Pikachu. **Bare-handed.**"
3.5 s	MOST OF YOU SAID → 2 · CARRY IT ✓
5.2 s	The wide: you tiny on a path, forty red eyes, 400 METERS to safety.

Template: your first six seconds

```
0.0 s  [your star mid-action, looking into the lens, with sound]
0.0 s  "[7 words or fewer. 'You', present tense, one RED word]"
3.5 s  MOST OF YOU SAID → [winning option] ✓
6.0 s  [one wide shot: the goal, the threat and the odds]
```

Chapter 3

The episode: a chase, not a lecture

Our best part and our worst part sat side by side. The difference wasn't the art. It was what the script asked the viewer to do.

	Part 3 (loved)	Part 4 (flopped)
Something happens	every ~3 s	every ~12 s
New facts to hold	about 6	about 30
Words per sentence	4.1	5.3
Voices	1 narrator	4 voices
Shots that move	78 of 79	37% of the runtime nearly still
Mood	dark, glowing, moving	bright, flat, static
Big, clip-able moment	yes, at 62%	none

Why Part 4 failed, in one line. It answered questions while you stood still. Part 3 asked questions while you ran. Answers release tension, so an episode built on explaining has nothing pulling the viewer forward.

Pacing

- **A new picture every 1.5 to 2.5 seconds,** and nothing held longer than 3.5 seconds before the vote.
- **Something happens about every three seconds,** and the story turns about every seven.
- **The kind of danger changes about every twenty seconds,** each one closer to your body than the last.
- **Run a ticking number** the whole way: a distance, a battery, a clock. Plant the number that pays off a minute before it does, and don't mention it until then.
- **One spectacle at 60 to 65% of the runtime:** three or four seconds, full frame, then a second or two of silence.
- **Each part is a full mini-arc,** 75 to 170 seconds: hook, threat, a rule, a twist, the cliffhanger.

Chapter 3, continued

Writing the narration

- **Second person, present tense, all the way.** "Your arm goes numb. It slips."
- **Four words a sentence, on average.** About half our Part 3 sentences were fragments.
- **Every line names something on screen right now.** If the words say "a boot", the picture is a boot, big and centred.
- **At most three explaining lines per part,** each 12 words or fewer, each paid off by action within five seconds.
- **Concrete nouns:** drill, nest, phone, boot, band. Save abstract words for the one emotional beat.
- **Never explain the mystery.** State the facts and move on. That's what makes the comments argue.



Part 3's spectacle, at 62% of the runtime

Three rhythm tools

Countdown triplets
"Three percent. Four. Nine."

Opposite pairs
"It wasn't spilling. It was saving."

One-word hits
"Fainted." "Run." "A boot."

Lines from Part 3, to read aloud

> "Your arm goes numb. It slips."

> "The buzzing behind you stops. And your pocket starts."

> "The phone goes hot. Sixty-eight. Forty. Ten."

> "It could get away. It doesn't."

> "Not trust. Not yet. But not fear."

Read your script out loud at the narrator's speed. If you run out of breath, the sentence is too long.

Chapter 3, continued

Escalation and shots

How the danger climbed in Part 3

0 s	A physical chase: a swarm, 400 metres to go.
12 s	A human plan: a net under a nest. "Someone knew that."
13 s	The thing you're saving hurts you. A viewer's fix brings relief.
36 s	Silence. A message with no signal. A photo of you asleep. A boot.
58 s	A trap: the swarm herds you, and your own rule becomes the choice.
70 s	Near-misses, each closer: the post, your eye, the fall.
85 s	The payoff: the battery you watched climb, then the blast.
103 s	Aftermath clues: a leg band, a beam, "close enough to watch".
120 s	A breather: dawn, the town.
136 s	The cold sting: the phone rings, and the man across the street has one like yours.

Shots

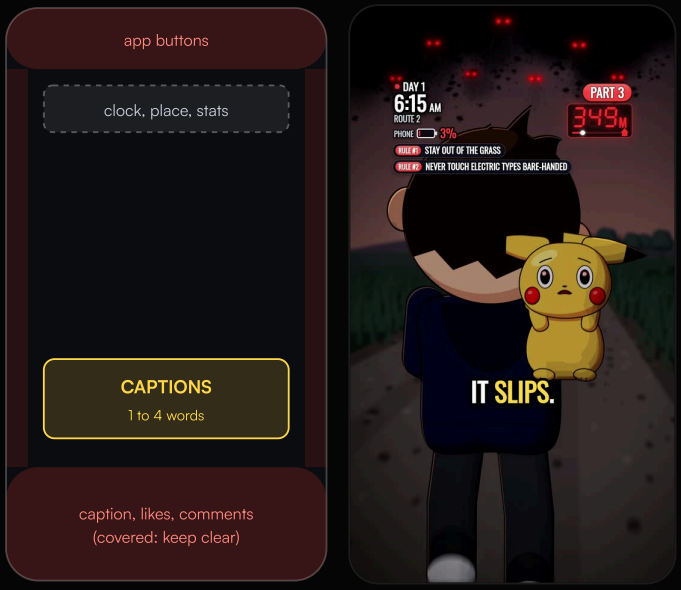
- **Build the part from four or five "home" setups** and keep returning to them, so the viewer is never lost: a rear chase, a front close-up, a prop close-up, a ground two-shot.
- **Inserts are reactions, never illustrations.** Object, then your face, then the same object closer. Never cut to something that's only being talked about.
- **Every shot moves:** running, pushing in, whipping across. A still frame reads as a mistake.
- **Darkness flatters simple drawings.** Glow, silhouettes and rim light hide shortcuts. Part 3 averaged 51 out of 255 for brightness; the bright, flat Part 4 averaged 94.

Chapter 3, continued

Captions, voice and the last check

Captions and safe zones

- **One to four words per chunk,** bold condensed capitals, white with a dark outline.
- **Colour one word per chunk:** yellow for new information, red for danger or the twist. Write numbers as digits: 3%, 6:11, 400 METERS.
- **Keep text in the middle band.** The bottom fifth of the screen is covered by the app's buttons, and phones crop the sides.
- **One text layer at a time:** a caption, or a card, or a stamp. Never three at once.



Voice

- **One narrator the audience knows,** about 2.6 words a second. Write fewer words rather than speeding up.
- **Flat text-to-speech for characters was our biggest complaint.** If a character can't be voiced well, the narrator tells us what they said.

The last check

- **Watch the full final at full size, as a stranger,** next to your best part, before you post.
- **Check every frame** for black, frozen or glitched frames. Ours caught a stretched clock, a black wedge and a one-frame snap that a normal watch-through missed.
- **No story changes after the picture is locked.** Every late change in Part 4 left a scar.

Chapter 4

The vote

The vote is the last thing people see and the first reason they come back. It has to feel like a real decision, about something real, right now.

- **Two options, three at most.**
- **Plant the vote's object earlier.** Part 1's phone at 3% became Part 3's battery, weapon and final choice: one percent, one call.
- **Physical verbs about what's in the last frame.** ANSWER IT or RUN beats "trust him" or "investigate".
- **Each option pulls a different instinct:** curiosity (find out), protection (keep it safe), escape, revenge.
- **Never offer the passive option.** Nobody votes to do nothing.
- **Say it three ways at once:** spoken, as a big caption, and as numbered pills with a one-line tag each.
- **Keep the vote and end card under seven seconds,** with something still moving underneath. Cut a sound off on the very last frame.



Part 6's vote: 11,786 answers in a day

Aim for a close split. A near-even result means every option was tempting. A lopsided one means you wasted a slot, and you'll feel it in the vote count.

Said three ways, from Part 3

Spoken	"One percent. One call. Answer it, or run for the Pokémon Center? Comment one or two."
Caption	ANSWER IT / OR RUN?
Pills	1 · ANSWER · 1% ONE CALL 2 · RUN · TO THE POKÉMON CENTER

Chapter 4, continued

Our four votes, and what each taught us

Vote	Votes	Split	Lesson
Part 3 Answer the call / Run	**7,667**	44 / 56	Two physical options, both tempting. A near-even split.
Part 4 Go out to him / Go with Oak / Stay inside / Find the girl	**6,367**	29 / 48 / 4 / 19	Too many options, and the passive one ("stay inside") got 4%. Also our weakest episode.
Part 5 Catch another / Ask how he knew / Find out who he is	**9,420**	31 / 42 / 27	Three strong options, each pulling over a quarter. Our healthiest split.
Part 6 Make Oak talk / Chase him / Play the tape	**11,786**	58 / 13 / 30	Our biggest vote, but "chase him" got 13%: one wasted slot.

Design your vote

Worksheet: fill this in before you write the ending

```
The object we planted earlier:  ____________________
Option 1 (a physical verb):     ____________________
   pulls on:  curiosity / protection / escape / revenge
Option 2 (a physical verb):     ____________________
   pulls on:  ____________________
Option 3 (only if it's as strong): _________________
Would I honestly be torn?       yes / no
The last frame shows:           ____________________
The sound that cuts off:        ____________________
How Part [N+1] opens for each option:
   1 → _____________   2 → _____________
```

Write both openings before you post. If you can't say how the next part opens for every option, the vote isn't real yet.

Chapter 5

The pinned comment and captions

Instagram says posts that ask people to comment "a specific word, number, or emoji" may not be shown to new people. So we ask for the number in exactly two places: the buttons inside the video, and one pinned comment. The caption asks the story question in plain words.

- **Pin three comments:** the vote with its closing time; a funny or heartfelt fan comment, swapped daily (never a theory, because fans read a pin as a yes); and a note for newcomers.
- **Keep voting open at least 24 hours,** including a full US daytime, so every timezone gets a say.
- **On YouTube you can pin only one comment,** so pin the vote. Write "Part 1 is linked above the title" instead of "pinned on the profile".

The vote pin

```
YOU DECIDE PART [N+1]
[Choice A], or [choice B]? Tell us what you'd do, and why.
1 = [A] · 2 = [B] · Votes close [day, time]
```

The newcomer pin

```
New here? Part 1 is pinned on the profile. Remember [a detail from Part 1]. It
matters later. 👀
```

The caption

```
Part [N] · You chose [the winning option].

[The question this part leaves you with, in words.]

[Choice A], [choice B] or [choice C]? The votes decide Part [N+1].
Parts 1-[N-1] are on the profile.
```

The title

```
[A 3 to 5 word hook] ([Series name] Part [N])
```

Chapter 6

Put the audience in the story

- **The stamp.** MOST OF YOU SAID → the winning option, on screen in the first four seconds.
- **The comment card.** SOME OF YOU SAID, with a real viewer's idea that changes the plot within three seconds. In our Part 3, "wrap it in your jacket" stopped the shocks at 19 seconds. Nothing makes people comment like seeing a comment on screen.
- **Reply like a person.** React to what they actually wrote. Never reuse one reply more than twice on a post, and never end a reply by asking for the vote.
- **Never confirm a theory.** Every theory gets the same reply, so nobody can read your face.
- **Hide or restrict hate and spam** without replying, and check "View hidden comments": real votes end up there too.
- **If the app says "Try again later",** stop all liking, replying and commenting for 24 to 48 hours.

Replies we used

Any theory

```
🧐 Saving this one. What's your proof?
```

A vote for option 1

```
Brave. [Why option 1 is bold]. What's
the first thing you [do]?
```

A vote that arrives late

```
Votes are closed: you chose [winner].
What's the first thing you'd do?
```

"When's the next part?"

```
Part [N+1]: [day]. Follow and you won't
miss it ⚡
```

"Is this AI?"

```
Fair question. Every frame is drawn in
code, no AI video. What did you think
of the ending?
```

A message that made your day

```
This made our day. Which moment got
you: [moment A], [moment B] or [moment
C]?
```

Chapter 7

Clues and covers

Hide one clue per part

Sends (shares) are Instagram's strongest signal to show a reel to new people, and people send clues. "Pause at 1:42, the instant after the flash" is a reason to forward a video to a friend.

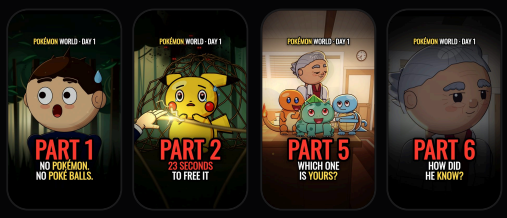
- **Hide it inside the spectacle** or in a background you hold for a beat: a silhouette in a flash, a shape in the grass, a time on a photo.
- **Point at it, don't explain it.** End the vote pin with "(There's a clue hidden behind him 👀)".
- **If nobody finds it in about 12 hours,** post a hint with the exact second (template below).
- **When someone finds it,** pin their comment, reply "👀 We're not saying anything," and pay it off in a later part.
- **Make surprises fair.** Every twist should pay off something the viewer already saw, so it feels clever, not random.

The hint

```
Pause at [time]. Don't look at [the obvious thing]. Look [where].
```

Covers and titles

- **Same layout every part:** the series label, a huge PART number, two hook lines (white, with one yellow word) and a face.
- **A face looking at something** beats a scene.
- **No spoilers** in the cover, title, caption or pinned comment. Ask about the twist; never show it.
- **Covers in a row** make your profile read like a series. People start at Part 1.



Chapter 8

Posting and growth

Most of a part's reach to new people happens in its first one or two days. Spend your energy there.

- **YouTube first, Instagram about an hour later.** "New parts hit YouTube first" gives Instagram followers a reason to tap the link in your bio.
- **Post often while it's hot.** The story accounts we studied post two or three parts a day in their first week, with Part 2 within 6 to 12 hours of Part 1. One breakout lifts every part after it, so have parts ready.
- **Chain the parts.** On Instagram, use Link a reel: each part links to the next, and the newest links back to Part 1. On YouTube, set each Short's related video the same way.
- **Twenty minutes a day,** in three short check-ins: reply to the best comments, check every message folder, post the Story.
- **Post a countdown Story** as soon as the next part's time is set, ending five minutes after you post. It shows everyone the time where they live, and reminds them.

The Story week

When	Story
Part night	Share the part, with a poll where one option means "watch it again".
Next morning	A quiz about a detail from the part: "What time did you wake up in Part 1?"
Next evening	A mystery with no sticker, so people can only answer by replying. That's how you get messages.
The day after	The best theories (no names), with an emoji slider: "How scared should you be?"
Vote closes	The result, with the same countdown added again, so everyone's reminders carry over.
After the next part	Last part's clue, behind a Reveal sticker.
Once a week	An "Add Yours" from one of your pictures, like "Your trainer name, Day 1".

Chapter 8, continued

Growth levers and settings

- **Trial Reels.** Instagram shows them only to people who don't follow you. A trial version of our Part 1 reached 228K views on its own. Make a 20 to 30 second trailer from Part 1's hook.
- **Shares come from clues and spectacles.** Build at least one of each into every part.
- **A broadcast channel,** if you have it: one line each time a part goes up.
- **Messages come from Story replies,** emoji reactions and Reveal stickers. Followers who arrive from reels see your Stories last, so ask for replies, not comments, on Stories.

The bio

```
[What it is, in one line].
You're the [role]. You vote what happens.
New parts on YouTube first 👇
```

Set once, on day one

- [ ] Highlights: START HERE, THEORIES, and SAFETY ("We never message first. We never run giveaways.").
- [ ] Sharing and reuse: allow sharing to Stories, reposts and remixes. Turn downloads off.
- [ ] Hidden Words on, with promo, collab, crypto and "DM me" added.
- [ ] Account Status: check you can still be recommended. Check again after any takedown.
- [ ] Limited interactions off. It hides messages from people who followed in the past week, which is nearly every new fan.
- [ ] Message controls: followers and others go to requests; Story replies from everyone; notifications on for the General tab.
- [ ] Your fan-made or copyright line saved as a text shortcut, if you use anyone else's world.

Read three numbers every day

- **Reach from people who don't follow you.** It should be most of your views. If it drops sharply after a change, undo the change. If it drops after a vote post, take the numbers out of the pinned comment too.
- **Shares.** They tell you which moments and clues travel. Build more of those.
- **Comments per 1,000 views.** Under 1 means the vote isn't landing. Make the options harder to choose between.

Chapter 9

What not to do

- **Bait wording.** "Comment 1 to unlock Part 4" or "Share or it dies" gets posts held back.
- **The vote on the cover or in the caption's first line.** Keep it in the video and the pin.
- **Bought followers, engagement pods, follow-unfollow, giveaways.** They're the patterns platforms punish.
- **Auto-DM tools.** They're exactly the pattern Instagram flags, and they message young fans first.
- **Messaging fans first,** or asking for real names, ages or selfies.
- **A talking episode.** If two characters explain the world for a minute, nothing is chasing anyone. That was our Part 4.
- **Four options, or a "do nothing" option.** Fewer votes, and one option nobody picks.
- **Opening on the past.** No recap, no reading out last part's results over a frozen frame.
- **Confirming a theory or hinting at the next part.** The argument is the engagement.
- **Re-uploading the parts stitched together,** or sending people to another app mid-story.
- **Announcing a time you might miss.** If you're late, post one Story with the new time, move the countdown and answer the "when?" comments. Never go silent.
- **Posting a final nobody has watched end to end.**
- **Using official art, music or logos** from someone else's world, or selling anything with their characters.

If a warning or takedown arrives

- **Don't panic-delete everything,** and don't fight it in public. Read which post was hit and why.
- **Check Account Status** in settings to see whether you can still be recommended.
- **First one:** remove any other post with the same problem. **Second one:** pause posting and rethink before going on.
- **Don't open a replacement account** and re-upload the same videos. That's against the rules too.
- **Original characters and worlds remove this risk entirely.** That's why the Arc Lab skill ships only original ones.

Chapter 10

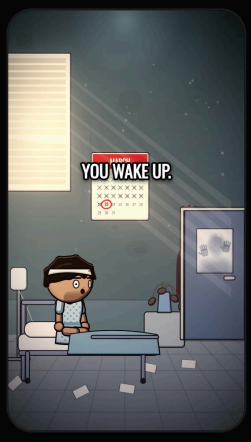
A second series: Day 23

Everything so far comes from Your Trainer Arc, after the audience arrived. Day 23 is the same loop on day one, before anyone has voted: an original zombie survival series we made with the Arc Lab Series Skill.

The premise. You wake from a coma on day 23 of the end of the world, in a small town where the dead walk, and the only one who came for you is a stray dog.

Episode 1, second by second

0.0 s	"You wake up. Something is at the door." The handle is already rattling on frame one.
3.2 s	"Twenty-three days." The ticking number: a calendar with days 1 to 22 crossed out and 23 circled in red.
9.5 s	"At the end of the hall, the doors are chained. And something is pushing back."
14.0 s	An eye in the gap between the doors, for about a second. That's the clue.
15.4 s	"Then a dog barks. It knows the way out." The companion makes the first move.
22.1 s	"**Almost.**" The empty street, and one figure in the road, 59% of the way in.
24.0 s	RULE #1 · STAY UNSEEN. "One turns. Then all of them."
27.3 s	The vote: "Run for the police car. Hide in the bus. Or go back inside. Comment one, two or three."



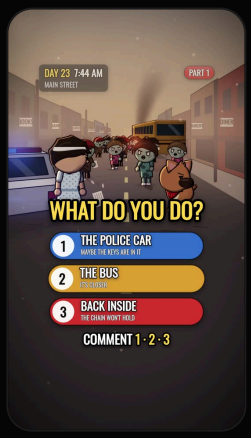
0.3 s: something at the door



0:14: the eye in the gap (zoomed in)



22 s: "Almost."



27 s: the vote

Chapter 10, continued

Planned before the first vote

The loop is easier to keep turning when the answers are decided before Episode 1 goes up. Day 23 started from a series bible: the world's laws, the cast, the mysteries and the episode where each one pays off. That file is never posted.

37.6 s Episode 1, from the first frame to the end of the vote	**77** spoken words, about 4.5 a sentence	**4** laws in the world's rulebook
3 vote options, each a place already on screen	**4** clues planted, two of them pointed at	**1,128** frames, every one checked before the final

These numbers come from the making, not from views: Episode 1 hadn't been posted when we wrote this.

What the plan decides

- **The world's laws come first.** The first one is on screen at 24 seconds: RULE #1 · STAY UNSEEN. One of the dead seeing you is enough, because when one turns, they all turn. A law the viewer can repeat gives every vote something to argue about.
- **One big answer and one new mystery per episode.** Episode 1 answers where everyone went: you slept for 23 days, and the town is dead. Then it opens a new question: who crossed off the days?
- **Clues are planted, then left alone.** Episode 1 plants four. The pinned comment points at two, the eye and the calendar. The other two sit in plain sight, unexplained. Each one already has the episode where it pays off.
- **Teach before you vote.** The police car and the bus are in every street shot before the vote, and "inside" is where you woke up. Nobody has to guess what an option means.
- **The companion makes choices.** The dog barks, turns, leads the way and stays by you when the street turns. It has at least four choices of its own every episode.
- **Dread first, gore never.** The dead are frightening by number and by silence: no wounds, no blood, no bites on screen.

Never post the bible. It holds every answer. A fan who guesses right gets "👀 We're not saying anything," and nothing more.

Chapter 10, continued

The Day 23 vote and posting pack

The chapter 4 worksheet, filled in for Episode 1

```
The object we planted earlier:  the police car and the bus, in every street shot
Option 1 (a physical verb):      RUN for the police car
   pulls on:  escape · tag: MAYBE THE KEYS ARE IN IT
Option 2 (a physical verb):      HIDE in the bus
   pulls on:  protection · tag: IT'S CLOSER
Option 3 (only if it's as strong): GO back inside
   pulls on:  curiosity · tag: THE CHAIN WON'T HOLD
Would I honestly be torn?        yes
The last frame shows:            you and the dog, turning to face the dead
The sound that cuts off:         the moans of the dead, on the last frame
How Episode 2 opens for each option:
   written for all three before posting (not printed here)
```

The pinned comments

Pin 1: the vote

```
YOU DECIDE EPISODE 2: 1 THE POLICE CAR · 2 THE BUS · 3 BACK INSIDE? Tell us what
you'd do, and why.
```

Pin 2: the clue

```
Something is looking at you at 0:14 👀 And look at the calendar again: who was
crossing off the days?
```

Three covers, no spoilers

- **One layout, three pictures:** the room, the calendar, your face. Pick the one that stops you scrolling.
- **None shows the street or the dead.** The twist stays inside the video.
- **The caption asks the question in words:** "Run for the police car, hide in the bus, or go back inside? The votes decide Episode 2."



Chapter 11

Checklists

Before you post

- [ ] Frame one is mid-action, with sound
- [ ] First line: 7 words or fewer, "you", one red word
- [ ] Last vote credited by second four
- [ ] Goal, threat and odds in one wide by second six
- [ ] Something happens every ~3 seconds
- [ ] A ticking number runs the whole part
- [ ] One spectacle at 60 to 65%, then silence
- [ ] One clue hidden in it
- [ ] Two or three physical options, none passive
- [ ] Vote and end card under 7 seconds
- [ ] Every frame checked; full final watched
- [ ] Cover, title and caption have no spoilers

Part night

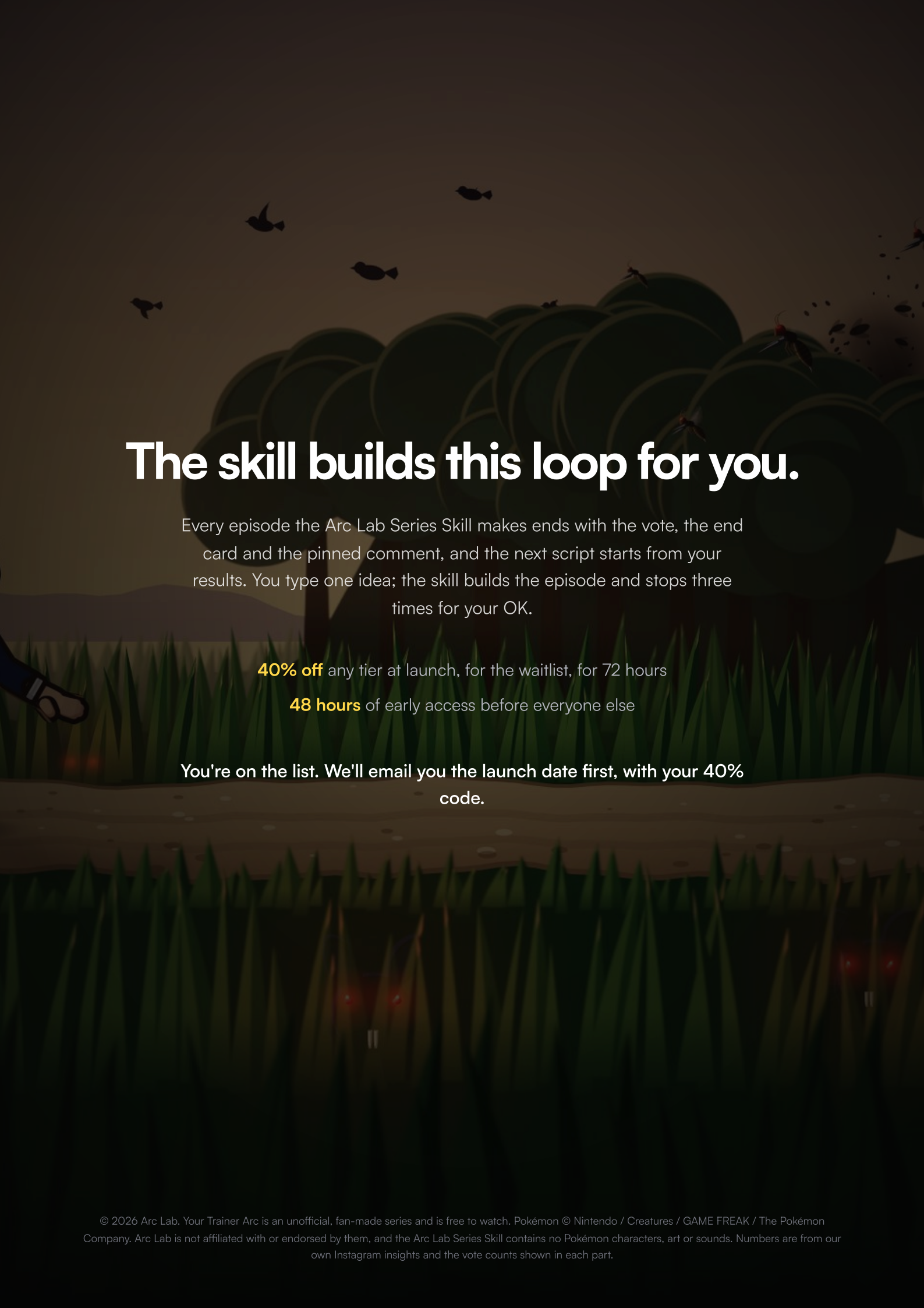
- [ ] YouTube first, Instagram an hour later
- [ ] Vote pin with closing time
- [ ] Newcomer pin
- [ ] Link the last part to this one
- [ ] Related video set on YouTube
- [ ] Share to Story, with a poll
- [ ] Reply to about 15 comments over the hour

The next two days

- [ ] Three check-ins a day, 5 to 10 minutes each
- [ ] Morning quiz Story
- [ ] Evening mystery Story, no sticker
- [ ] Clue hint if nobody has found it
- [ ] Count the vote and post the result
- [ ] Countdown for the next part

Every week

- [ ] Read reach from non-followers, shares and comments per 1,000 views
- [ ] Plan the next three parts, each ending on a real choice
- [ ] Start an Add Yours from one of your pictures
- [ ] Save the best viewer ideas for a SOME OF YOU SAID card
- [ ] Post one Trial Reel trailer from Part 1's hook
- [ ] Repeat the SAFETY Story: "We never message first."



The skill builds this loop for you.

Every episode the Arc Lab Series Skill makes ends with the vote, the end card and the pinned comment, and the next script starts from your results. You type one idea; the skill builds the episode and stops three times for your OK.

40% off any tier at launch, for the waitlist, for 72 hours

48 hours of early access before everyone else

You're on the list. We'll email you the launch date first, with your 40% code.

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